

Sudden farewell

Posted originally on the [Archive of Our Own](https://archiveofourown.org/works/54888898) at <https://archiveofourown.org/works/54888898>.

Rating:	Teen And Up Audiences
Archive Warning:	Major Character Death
Category:	M/M
Fandom:	Batfamily - Fandom
Relationship:	Tim Drake/Jason Todd
Characters:	Jason Todd , Tim Drake
Additional Tags:	Blood and Injury , Gunshot Wounds , Graphic Description , Hurt No Comfort , Love Confessions , Unrequited Love , Pining
Language:	English
Stats:	Published: 2024-04-01 Words: 1,339 Chapters: 1/1

Sudden farewell

by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

Jason is no stranger to pain. But this is a kind he's never felt before.

He rushes forward and catches Tim's limp body mid-fall.

Short ficlet inspired by artwork I've found on Twitter.

Notes

Thanks to Mandy and Bio for helping with figuring out the wounds situation. Thanks to Karukos for the quick betaread.

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

- Inspired by [A final kiss](#) by XANT

He is no stranger to pain and trauma. There's very little that can shock him these days.

And yet.

The world blurs, his field of vision feeling like it switched to a wider lens — expanding, distorting and zooming out. Colours and sounds lose details, become dull, more distant. It feels as if he is suddenly experiencing the world from a vantage point three steps behind his body. He recognises it for what it is; every ounce of his being tries to prevent him from registering what's happening.

He does not take kindly to this kind of mutiny. Being present and alert — being able to think clearly — is all a vigilante has in the end. It's all that's between you and death when push comes to shove. So he cannot disassociate, even if he probably should, even if his mind desperately wants to.

He cannot.

So he pushes through; frowns, blinks, bites his lip for the pain to shock him back to reality. When that's not enough, he resorts to growling under his breath, attempting to summon the rage he always carries back up from his subconscious; anger has always helped ground him when the scared animal of his body tried to shy away and hide from danger.

In an instant, the tables turn and the animal of his mind morphs from prey to predator. With adrenaline now filling his veins, the world becomes clearer than it was before it all started, despite the pouring rain. His vision sharpens once again, all details return. He scans the situation, muscles tight and ready to pounce. He immediately zeroes in on the issue that nearly stunned him dead to a screeching halt.

It all happens within the span of but a heartbeat. The deafening bangs of gunshots don't even finish echoing in the almost empty park. Tim's limp body doesn't even have time to hit the ground.

Jason is no stranger to pain. But this is a kind he's never felt before.

He rushes forward, his heart suddenly just as tight as his muscles. His stomach is tying itself into knots. It's hard to breathe. But he's there, he's conscious. He can do something.

He must.

So he musters all the strength that the stress can give him. His long strides and sudden surge of energy allow him to catch Tim mid-fall. Still, between the pouring rain and the pouring blood, his hands nearly slip.

Jason kneels on the ground with Tim held gingerly in his arms. Everything else loses meaning and Tim becomes the only thing he can see. The black hair, mussled by wind and fighting, drenched in cold rain. The pale skin, marred with bruises and scratches. The toned muscles, now slack and useless.

The red blood covering Tim's abdomen, flowing freely out of three gaping gunshot wounds, soaking into the already red costume until it's so saturated with gore that it looks nearly black.

"Why—" Jason mumbles under his breath, hands flying down in an attempt to stop the bleeding. They're all armed and protected. A normal bullet shouldn't have caused more than nasty bruises, maybe a cracked rib. "How—"

Tim's eyes follow Jason's hands, then start darting around, assessing the situation. "Kevlar's old," he sighs quietly, not without effort. He coughs, interrupting himself with a swear that morphs into a strained whine of pain halfway. Despite how hurt he is, he keeps speaking, strong and level-headed as always, even in the face of danger. "Must've hit a weak spot."

He peeks down at where Jason's trying to stop the bleeding. The pressure that Jason's applying is very clearly not enough, though not for a lack of trying. There's simply too much blood — it spills between Jason's fingers and pools on Tim's belly, then runs down his sides to form a puddle around him. This can mean only one thing — one of the bullets must've opened an abdominal artery. With every second, he's losing deadly amounts of blood.

Tim makes himself cough again as if to further test his wounds. This time, his mouth fills with blood, and he doesn't even have enough control over his numbing body to spit it out. It spills over the lip and drips down his cheek. "Lungs are busted, too." The dull wheezing sound that he makes when he tries to take in a deeper breath confirms the diagnosis.

He's not making it, they both know it. If he won't bleed out within minutes, he'll drown choking on his own blood. Tim's story — the story of the best Robin of them all, of the best vigilante Gotham has ever seen, of the best person Jason has ever met — will end here. In the middle of nowhere, on an unremarkable stormy Thursday night. Bested by a couple of lucky bullets to the chest that just so happened to hit a weak spot in his costume.

The man he has grown to admire far more than he ever had any right to will die in his arms.

Jason inhales sharply, trying to steady himself. He pushes even harder against Tim's wounds as if that would make a difference.

"Stop," Tim demands, mumbling, voice distinctly weaker than just a moment before. He attempts to swat at Jason's hands as if the act of uselessly trying to save him somehow offends him. "There's no point."

"I know." Jason decides he won't tell Tim pretty lies, won't try to reassure him. It would feel wrong to tell him to be calm or make him believe he can make it out of here. "But I'm not going anywhere," he says instead. His voice loses the deep, rough edge it usually has, and he barely manages to whisper now.

Neither of them would ever admit that they're scared, not even on death's door. But Jason knows. He knows that being alone is the worst feeling to experience when you feel your life slip away. If nothing else, he can do this one thing for Tim — he can stay.

Tim focuses his gaze on Jason, and Jason unwaveringly holds his cold stare. For a moment they're frozen like that, then Tim smiles weakly, seemingly understanding the grace that Jason's offering. "Thank you," he says, then lets his body slack and hang back, vulnerable and at peace for the first time since possibly forever.

Jason does true on his promise and stays with Tim. He witnesses his departure, nothing more. He doesn't talk, doesn't do much of anything — simply is a stable presence, something to soothe the primal fear of being alone. He's simply there when blood bubbles out of Tim's mouth and gunshot wounds, when the pouring rain causes wine-dark streaks to run down Tim's face, when the crimson puddle around them grows, like a blooming flower. He's simply there, holding him close when Tim's ragged, laboured breathing finally comes to a halt.

He waits until the light fully goes out in Tim's eyes before he allows himself to grieve losing the love of his life. To confess his feelings for Tim in a moment like this would've been... unfair. Cruel, even. It'd only add to the suffering that one's last moments are, to the crushing weight of knowing each breath brings you closer to death. There was no point in telling Tim, even if Jason desperately wanted to, when neither of them could do anything about it.

But now that Tim is no longer with him, it doesn't matter anymore. He doesn't have to pretend for Tim's sake. His own is the only heart he'll break now, after all.

So he embraces his pain, openly and fully — the pain of losing something you never really had, of losing the chance for it to happen. He grieves, the only way he can think of. With tears pouring down his cheeks much like the rain, he slowly leans in and kisses Tim. The lips are still warm, just as plush as he always imagined they would be. He could almost pretend that Tim's just sleeping, safe and sound and peaceful.

Almost.

End Notes

Alternate ending:

Seventeen miles north of there, holed up in an unmarked little bunker from which he orchestrated his fake death, horrified Red Robin silently stares at the live feed from his suit displayed on his screen.

Please [drop by the Archive and comment](#) to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!